

This made it appear to be a genetic matter. Either you were “born that way” or you weren’t. But Mischel says it’s more complicated than that. It’s like learning to use a computer. You won’t do it if you don’t have access to a computer.²

Broadly, from our point of view, we interpret that to mean that you won’t develop the capacity for forbearance unless you have a reason to.

If there is one thing that marks families with money over the long term it is this: delayed gratification.

There are psychologists who believe that the performance of different cultures can be largely explained by this single point. Those who look ahead to the future and those that plan for it—surprise, surprise!—have better futures.

There are even some geo-theorists who believe that the relative outperformance of certain ethnic groups of people can be explained in the same way. How come Europe grew rich while Africa remained poor? How come North America is relatively rich, while South America is relatively poor? (However, this was a better question a few years ago, when the differences were more obvious.) How come, generally, colder countries are more successful than warmer ones?

The reason, they believe, is that colder climates force a longer-term view.

Believe it or not, there are still groups of primitive hunter-gatherers living on the African savannah. Anthropologists studying them have found little sense of the future. They do not prepare for it because they don’t need to. One day’s hunt is much like the next. One day’s nuts and berries differ little from those of the day before. No need to think much about the future or to plan for it.

Presumably, people very similar to these primitive tribes spread into Europe and Asia, and there they encountered new challenges. Thirty thousand years ago, there were human tribes following the caribou along the face of Europe’s continental glacier.

Near our house in France there is a cave that provides evidence. For thousands of years, a group of hunters made the cave a stopping point. But it was only a stopping point. They followed the herds of caribou that ranged over Europe at the time. As the weather changed, so did their lifestyle. They